Forgiven People Forgive

Because God has forgiven us a debt we could never pay, we forgive others from the heart, again and again.

Main passage	Matthew 18:21-35 (KJV)
Topic	Forgiveness
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Forgiveness does not keep count	7 min
Teaching point 2: We have been forgiven a debt we could never pay	7 min
Teaching point 3: Forgiven people forgive from the heart	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask the class: "Is there a limit to how many times you should forgive the same person for the same thing?" Let a few people answer honestly. Most of us have a number in mind, even if we have never said it out loud. Peter had a number too, and he thought it was a generous one. Today we will hear what Jesus said to him.

Teacher note: Keep this light and do not ask anyone to name a person who has hurt them. The aim is only to bring our private "limits" into the open.

Scripture (3 min)

Matthew 18:21-35

21 Then came Peter to him, and said, Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times? 22 Jesus saith unto him, I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven.

[23] Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened unto a certain king, which would take account of his servants. [24] And when he had begun to reckon, one was brought unto him, which owed him ten thousand talents. [25] But forasmuch as he had not to pay, his lord commanded him to be sold, and his wife, and children, and all that he had, and payment to be made. [26] The servant therefore fell down, and worshipped him, saying, Lord, have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. [27] Then the lord of that servant was moved with compassion, and loosed him, and forgave him the debt. [28] But the same servant went out, and found one of his fellowservants, which owed him an hundred pence: and he laid hands on him, and took him by the throat, saying, Pay me that thou owest. [29] And his fellowservant fell down at his feet, and besought him, saying, Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. [30] And he would not: but went and cast him into prison, till he should pay the debt. [31] So when his fellowservants saw what was done, they were very sorry, and came and told unto their lord all that was done. [32] Then his lord, after that he had called him, said unto him, O thou wicked servant, I forgave thee all that debt, because thou desiredst me: [33] Shouldest not thou also have had compassion on thy fellowservant, even as I had pity on thee? [34] And his lord was wroth, and delivered him to the tormentors, till he should pay all that was due unto him. [35] So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses.

Read the passage aloud, or use three readers: a narrator, Peter, and Jesus (who also speaks for the king).

Background (5 min)

Matthew 18 is a chapter about life together among Jesus' followers. It opens with the disciples arguing over who would be greatest (18:1). Jesus answers with a little child, a warning against causing others to stumble, the parable of the lost sheep, and steps for going to a brother who has sinned against you (18:15-20). Peter's question grows out of that teaching: if I must go to my brother and forgive him, how often?

Both Albert Barnes and Adam Clarke note that the Jewish teachers of the day held that a man should be forgiven three times but not a fourth. Peter more than doubled that and added one, offering seven, the number of completeness. Jesus answered with "seventy times seven", which is not a new limit to count up to but a way of saying "do not keep count at all."

The amounts in the parable are deliberately enormous. A talent was a very large sum, about six thousand days' wages for a labourer, so ten thousand talents was a debt no servant could ever repay. A "penny" (Greek denarius) was one day's wage, so a hundred pence was a real but manageable debt of a few months' pay. The first debt is beyond counting; the second is small beside it.

Teacher note: If someone asks, the selling of the wife and children (v. 25) reflects the debt laws of the ancient world. Barnes cautions against pressing every detail of a parable; the story exists to teach one main truth about forgiveness.

Teaching point 1: Forgiveness does not keep count (7 min)

Peter wanted to know where forgiveness could stop. Jesus' answer removes the stopping point. The question "How often must I forgive?" already assumes that forgiveness will run out some day. Jesus tells us to stop keeping the score.

Supporting verses

Matthew 18:21-22: Then came Peter to him, and said, Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times? Jesus saith unto him, I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven.

Luke 17:3-4: Take heed to yourselves: If thy brother trespass against thee, rebuke him; and if he repent, forgive him. And if he trespass against thee seven times in a day, and seven times in a day turn again to thee, saying, I repent; thou shalt forgive him.

Colossians 3:13: Forbearing one another, and forgiving one another, if any man have a quarrel against any: even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye.

> *"There is something of ill-nature in scoring up the injuries we forgive, as if we would allow ourselves to be revenged when the measure is full."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 18:21-35

Handout blanks (answers)

Jesus told Peter to forgive not seven times, but **seventy** times seven.

Forgiveness that keeps **count** is waiting for the day it can stop.

Teaching point 2: We have been forgiven a debt we could never pay (7 min)

The first servant could not pay, and he could never have paid. His promise, "I will pay thee all," was hopeless. The king did not give him more time; he cancelled the whole debt out of compassion. That is the picture of what God has done for us in Christ. Our debt of sin was beyond our power to repay, and God forgave it freely.

Supporting verses

Matthew 18:23-27 (read from the Bible)

Psalm 103:10-12: He hath not dealt with us after our sins; nor rewarded us according to our iniquities. For as the heaven is high above the earth, so great is his mercy toward them that fear him. As far as the east is from the west, so far hath he removed our transgressions from us.

Ephesians 1:7: In whom we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of his grace;

Romans 5:8: But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

> *"so is it impossible for a sinner, infinitely indebted to Divine justice, ever to pay a mite out of the talent."*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 18:25

Handout blanks (answers)

The servant owed a debt he could **never** repay.

The king forgave the whole debt because he was moved with **compassion**.

Teaching point 3: Forgiven people forgive from the heart (7 min)

The same servant walked out and seized a man who owed him a small sum. What makes the story shocking is that he had just been forgiven so much. Jesus says that forgiveness received and forgiveness given belong together. We forgive because we have been forgiven, and we forgive "from the heart" (v. 35), not only with our words.

Supporting verses

Matthew 18:28-35 (read from the Bible)

Ephesians 4:32: And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

Matthew 6:14-15: For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.

> *"God teaches us what to do to a fellow-sinner, by what He does to us."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 18:30

> *"From your hearts. That is, not merely in words, but really and truly to feel and act towards him as if he had not offended us."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 18:35

Handout blanks (answers)

We forgive others because God has first **forgiven** us.

Jesus asks us to forgive from the **heart**, not only in words.

Teacher note: Some in the class may have suffered real abuse. Forgiving from the heart means giving up revenge and the right to repay. It does not mean pretending no harm was done, refusing to report a crime, or trusting someone who is still dangerous. Jesus himself speaks of rebuke and repentance (Luke 17:3). Barnes, on verse 21, says forgiveness is "to declare that we will not harbour malice," which is a decision we can make even while trust is slowly rebuilt.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think Peter offered the number seven? What does that tell us about how we usually think of forgiveness?

He thought he was being generous (more than double the common teaching of three times). It shows we often treat forgiveness as a limited supply that eventually runs out.

2. Compare the two debts in the story. What is Jesus teaching by making the first one so huge?

Our sin against God is beyond anything we could repay; what others owe us is small by comparison. Seeing the size of our own debt changes how we treat others' debts.

3. The servant was forgiven but did not become forgiving. How can a person receive mercy and stay unmerciful?

He did not let the king's mercy change his heart; he treated it as good luck rather than grace. Forgiveness that has really reached us shows itself in how we treat others.

4. What is the difference between forgiving someone and trusting them again?

Forgiving means giving up revenge and the claim to repayment, from the heart. Trust may take time to rebuild and depends on the other person's repentance and changed behaviour.

5. What makes forgiving "from the heart" hard, and what helps?

Hurt, pride, and replaying the wrong make it hard. Remembering how much we have been forgiven, praying for the person, and asking God for help make it possible.

Application (3 min)

This week, think of one person you have been "keeping score" against. Pray for them by name each day. Ask God to help you let go of the debt in your heart. If it is right and safe to do so, take one step toward peace: a kind word, a note, or a phone call.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Gracious Father, we owed you a debt we could never pay, and you forgave it all for Jesus' sake. Forgive us for the times we have kept score against others. Soften our hearts, so that we forgive as we have been forgiven, not only with our words but from the heart. Give us wisdom where trust must be rebuilt, and courage to seek peace. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 18:21-35

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 18:25

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Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 18:35

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